EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

# Who Was Rav Saadiah Gaon? The Man Who Saved the Calendar

**Given Monday 22 January 2024** · Emunot VeDeot, Introduction

**Sefer:** Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon
**Essay/Chapters:** Opening shiur: a biography of Rav Saadia Gaon and an overview of the book
**Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 22 January 2024, on Zoom

*These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.*

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## Where We Are: The Third Book

The Rabbi opened a new series. About four years earlier the group had begun a journey through the classic books of Jewish thought:

| # | Book | Author |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | **Derech Hashem** (The Way of God) | The Ramchal |
| 2 | **Da'at Tevunot** | The Ramchal |
| 3 | **Emunot VeDeot** (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) | **Rav Saadia Gaon** |

The group had "unanimously decided" that the third book would be Rav Saadia's. The usual English title is *The Book of Beliefs and Opinions*, and the Rabbi promised to come back to whether that is a precise translation (he did, the following week).

### Written in Arabic

"One important point to put straight at the beginning": **Emunot VeDeot was written in Arabic.** It was later translated into Hebrew, and only in the twentieth century into English (an abridged translation in **1946**, and the full one a couple of years later). Rav Saadia wrote almost all his commentaries and books in Arabic, and so did many of the Geonim, because **"in order for their works to be accessible they have to be in the vernacular,"** and the vernacular of the time was Arabic.

The plan for the evening:

1. **The life of Rav Saadia Gaon**, with the controversies he lived through.
2. **An overview of the book**: who it is written for, whom it argues against, and its key ideas.
3. **How to get hold of the text.**

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## Part 1: The Life of Rav Saadia Gaon

### Egypt and Tiberias

- **Born in Egypt in 892**, at the end of the ninth century, "over 1,100 years ago."
- Rav Saadia traces his family back to **Rabbi Chanina ben Dosa** of the Talmud, and through him to **Yehudah**. "At least in Saadia's eyes, he has a lineage all the way back to Yehudah."
- Recognised from a young age as a very bright student, he was **sent to Eretz Yisrael to study, to Tiberias**.

Tiberias at that time was "the hotbed" of the grammarians and the masoretes:

- The text of the Torah we have today goes back to **Ben Asher**, the great grammarian of Tiberias, whose text is essentially that of the **Aram Tzova (the Aleppo Codex)**.
- Many argue, at least in the academic approach, that it was around this time and in Tiberias that **the system of *ta'amim* (the cantillation marks)** was developed.

This is why, the Rabbi explained, Rav Saadia was so concentrated on **language and the precision of words**. He returned to Egypt at **15**, and at about **20** published his **first book: a dictionary of the Hebrew language**.

### Dunash and *Dror Yikra*

The dictionary heavily influenced his student **Dunash ben Labrat**. "Who's heard of Dunash? No one's heard of Dunash?" Someone on Zoom got it: **Dror Yikra**. If you look at the first letters of the stanzas of that beautiful Shabbat song, **they spell דונש, Dunash**. Dunash became a famous grammarian, and many of our grammar rules come from him. "You can see how important language was to Saadia."

Rav Saadia also spent some time in **Aleppo** in his twenties, but was mostly in Egypt, and later ended up in **Bavel (Iraq)**: "a happy time, but a tragic time as well."

"It's not an exaggeration to say that Saadia in different ways actually saved Judaism."

### The calendar crisis of 922

**Background.** Originally the months and festivals were fixed by the sighting of the moon, with the Hachamim of Eretz Yisrael in charge of sanctifying the new month. Then **Hillel (Hillel II, not the Hillel of Beit Hillel)**, around **359 CE**, **fixed the calendar**. From then on the authority of Eretz Yisrael over the months and festivals was effectively over, and the fixed calendar spread across the Jewish world, unchallenged for centuries.

**The challenge.** In the early tenth century one of the Geonim of Eretz Yisrael, **Rabbi Aharon ben Meir**, argued that the Hachamim of Eretz Yisrael still had the main jurisdiction over the calendar, and that the right to decide the months and festivals should return to them, not to the Geonim of Bavel.

**The result.** The argument grew so fierce that **in 922**:

| | Pesach began on |
|---|---|
| **Eretz Yisrael** | **Sunday** |
| **Bavel and the rest of the world** | **Tuesday** |

"So whilst in Israel they were eating matzah on Seder night and not having any chametz, a few miles away in Iraq they were having chametz." And at the end of the festival, the Jews of Eretz Yisrael were eating chametz while the rest of the world was still keeping Pesach.

"If this would continue, this would destroy Judaism. Because we're all based upon our festivals and our calendar, and we have to be on the same page."

**Rav Saadia, aged about 30**, wrote many letters and responsa on the issue, especially to the Hachamim of Eretz Yisrael. He **convinced Rabbi Aharon ben Meir's own colleagues** that they were wrong; they left him and sided with Rav Saadia. It caused a conflict between the two men, "but he managed to get through that." It happened for one year and never again. "Just imagine we had a situation nowadays where Jews in one part of the world are celebrating at a different time. That would be crazy."

## The fight against the Karaites

His second great battle was against the **Karaites (*Kara'im*)**. He wrote strongly and polemically against them and made many enemies.

**Where they came from (eighth century).** In Bavel the **Reish Galuta (the Exilarch)** held full political power over the Jewish community and represented it before the Caliph. When the Reish Galuta died, his eldest son **Anan ben David**, a great scholar, expected to succeed him. The Hachamim distrusted him, "probably for good reason, as we're going to see," and persuaded the Caliph to appoint his younger brother instead.

Anan was furious "and breaks away, as you do when you're upset about something in your shul: you break away and create your own shul. Nothing new there."

He rejected rabbinic Judaism: "these rabbis, they make up the Torah." The name **Kara'im** comes from **מקרא, *mikra***, the verse: only what is written, nothing else. The idea went back to the **Sadducees**, who had fizzled out; Anan reignited it. The sect had real influence for centuries and still existed in the Rambam's time.

**What literalism looks like.** In that week's parashah, Beshalach, Moshe tells the people to gather a double portion of manna on Friday, and says:

**אל יצא איש ממקמו ביום השביעי** (Shemot 16:29) .No man shall leave his place on the seventh day

Read with the Oral Torah, this means do not go out of your domain to gather manna. Read literally, **"stay in your chair the whole Shabbat"**, and the really observant Karaites never left their chairs on Shabbat. Likewise, since the Torah says **לא תבערו אש** (do not kindle fire in your dwellings), they sat **in pitch darkness** on Friday night and had **no hot food**, even from a fire lit before Shabbat.

**Why we eat *chamin* on Shabbat morning.** This, the Rabbi said, is where the custom comes from. The **Rema** in the Shulchan Aruch writes that someone who deliberately refuses hot food

on Shabbat morning should be checked, because **he may be a heretic**. The custom of keeping food hot overnight developed **to counter the Karaites**: there is nothing wrong with enjoying a fire lit before Shabbat.

### The dispute with the Exilarch

His "greatest conflict and saddest time" was with the Reish Galuta, **David ben Zakkai**.

- **928 (aged 36):** David ben Zakkai brought Rav Saadia from Egypt and appointed him **Rosh Yeshivah (Gaon) of Sura**. Bavel had the two great yeshivot familiar from the Talmud, **Sura and Pumbedita**, which continued all the way through the Geonic period.
- **Why:** the Reish Galuta felt that the Gaon of Pumbedita, **Kohen Tzedek**, was not subservient enough. He wanted a heavyweight to re-establish the authority of the Exilarch.

The Rabbi stressed that the Exilarch was **a political position, not a rabbinic one**. "The best equivalent I can give for nowadays is probably the head of the Board of Deputies," except that the Board represents a small segment of the community, while the Reish Galuta was over everyone. "He wasn't a *talmid chacham*. He's a political position. So he wants a rabbi to support him."

At first it worked. Rav Saadia "comes in with big shoulders" and the Gaon of Pumbedita was diminished. But the Exilarch "soon finds out that Saadia is a principled person," and within **two years** a huge fight broke out:

1. A dispute arose over **the will of a wealthy member of the community**. To execute it his way, the Exilarch needed the signatures of both Geonim.
2. The weakened Gaon of Pumbedita quickly signed.
3. **Rav Saadia refused.** He thought the interpretation of the will was completely wrong.
4. The Exilarch's son **publicly humiliated Rav Saadia in the synagogue** and **beat at least one of his children**.
5. Rav Saadia, who had only religious power, **put the Exilarch in *cherem***.
6. The dispute went to **the Caliph**, who sided with the Exilarch. **Rav Saadia lost his position in 930.**

### Seven years out of office, and forgiveness

For **seven years** he had no position. "This is a time where he writes a lot," and it is believed that **Emunot VeDeot was written during these years**. In **937** the community, "as communities change, presidents change," reappointed him **Gaon of Sura**, which he remained until his death in **942**.

"Unbelievably, in 940 David ben Zakkai passes away, and Saadia looks after his son, the one who had humiliated him." He did not bear a grudge; he had forgiven what happened.

### Summary of his life

| Age / year | Event |
|---|---|
| **892** | Born in Egypt; traces his line to Yehudah |
| Youth | Studies Hebrew language in **Tiberias**; returns to Egypt at **15** |
| About **20** | Publishes his **Hebrew dictionary** |
| 20s | Time in **Aleppo**; mostly in Egypt |
| **30 (922)** | **Saves the unity of the calendar** in the Ben Meir dispute |
| **36 (928)** | Appointed **Gaon of Sura** |
| **930** | **Deposed** after the dispute with David ben Zakkai |
| **930-937** | Seven years without a post; writes Emunot VeDeot |
| **937-942** | Gaon of Sura again until his death, aged about 50 |

"A very short life," but he goes down in history as **one of the great Geonim of the Babylonian period**.

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## Part 2: The Book

### Philosophy was not a luxury

Today we think of philosophy as a luxury, something some people study at university. In the Middle Ages, the Rabbi said, it was the opposite: **philosophy was a fundamental part of refining your intellect.** If you did not know philosophy, you had not really refined your mind. Throughout the Sefaradi Rishonim, philosophy was integral to understanding God, understanding Torah, "and understanding just being a Jew." Rav Saadia will argue strongly that **reason, logic and intellect are fundamental to understanding Torah and understanding God.**

### The father of Jewish philosophy

**Emunot VeDeot is the very first book to establish Jewish philosophy in a structured manner.**

- Nobody before Rav Saadia had done this.
- Many ideas we take for granted, often credited to the Rambam, **originated with Rav Saadia**.
- "I wouldn't say it's the most important book of Jewish philosophy. I don't think it is. But it's a fundamental one, because it lays the roots for all future philosophy."
- **The Rambam quotes Rav Saadia many times, in the original Arabic.** He sometimes disagreed with him, but highly respected him.

## Two audiences

Rav Saadia writes in his introduction (which the class would study in the coming weeks) that he is addressing two groups, "and unfortunately both groups still exist very much today":

| Group | Description |
|---|---|
| **1. The pious without understanding** | Jews who consider themselves religious. "They know very well which hechsher to look at when buying a product," but ask them a basic question about their beliefs and they cannot answer. **"That's tragic,"** he says. You cannot be a pious Jew without understanding Hashem and the philosophy of Judaism. |
| **2. The non-observant** | He wants to show them **they can also have faith**. |

So this is already an early attempt "to bridge the gap between those who are observant and those who are less observant." The Rabbi added: "Many of us, myself included, fall into the first category. We do lots of things we don't necessarily understand."

## Three targets

He asked the class which three groups the book aims at. The answer: **Christianity, Islam and the Karaites.**

**1. Christianity.** Rav Saadia is extremely polemical, especially about **the Trinity**: a grave violation of monotheism and of the principle that **God has no body**, which he is probably the first to articulate clearly. "How can you say God was killed?" His position, "which may not be very politically correct nowadays," is that **everything positive in Christianity comes from Judaism, and the rest is nonsense**.

The Rabbi pointed out that this has **halachic ramifications**, and that where you live shapes how freely you can speak:

**Masechet Avodah Zarah** forbids doing business with idol worshippers **three days before their festivals**, since the profit leads them to thank their idols. **Rabbeinu Tam** in twelfth-century France was asked how Jews in France and England could trade before Christmas: "We should have to close down our shops in December!" He "squeezes his way out" and rules that **Christianity is *shittuf***: imperfect monotheism. Forbidden for a Jew to believe, but not pagan. **Rav Saadia rejects that: for him it is avodah zarah, full stop.** And he can say so because he does not have to be circumspect: he is not living in Christian Europe.

**2. Islam.** Here he is more careful. **Muslims are perfect monotheists**, a position the Rambam repeats two hundred years later. Rav Saadia does not speak about Muhammad in the disparaging terms the Rambam uses ("I'm telling you what the Rambam writes, I'm not saying that"). He rationally disproves some of their claims, but his **main objection, to Islam and Christianity alike, is exclusivity**:

"How can you say God is merciful when, according to your belief, the majority of human beings in the world are not going to have a place in heaven?"

The Rabbi worked it through: even granting that all of the world's roughly 3.2 billion Christians fully believe, they are still not the majority of 8 billion people, so on that belief most of

humanity is damned. The same is true of the roughly 2.8 billion Muslims. Ask Rav Saadia: how can a merciful God do that?

**The Jewish alternative**, which will fit Rav Saadia's definition of the chosen people: Hashem created a chosen people **with a duty to reflect morality across the world**, but **every human being, provided they are not pagans and live moral lives, has a portion in the World to Come.**

**3. The Karaites**, as described above. Some of these battles are less relevant to us now, "because the situations have changed," but "it's the way he articulates the arguments which we can learn from."

### "He loves categories"

"Something I have to tell you about Saadia. He loves categories. He loves numbers. He loves boxing things up into three this, four that, ten this." He will do it all through the book: numbered arguments for, numbered arguments against.

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## Part 3: Key Ideas of the Book

### 1. Revelation is not the highest level

Here Rav Saadia **differs greatly from Rabbi Yehudah HaLevi**, author of the Kuzari. Rav Saadia writes that there are **four ways** to understand God and Judaism. As the Rabbi presented them:

| # | Way | Explanation |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | **Intellect** | How **Avraham** understood God: look around the world and you will understand God and Torah |
| 2 | **Logic / deduction** | Once you have knowledge, you derive one thing from another and piece things together |
| 3 | **Tradition (*mesorah*)** | What people tell you, handed down |
| 4 | **Revelation** | Har Sinai |

On tradition: Rav Saadia says that **humans are unique** in being able to accumulate knowledge and pass it on. A monkey or a dolphin can be trained, but it cannot teach what it learned to its young. (The Rabbi asked someone to research whether that is still believed today: "that was at least the belief of science at the time.") After all, how does anyone learn to speak? From what people tell them.

**So why do we need Har Sinai at all?** Rav Saadia's answer, very simply: **most people do not like to use their intellect**; even those who do will not patiently use their logic; and many will not patiently listen to the views of others before them. **Revelation is "a catch-all" for those who cannot develop their understanding themselves.**

"Which means, essentially, revelation is the lowest level, or it's not high up. Whereas for Rabbi Yehudah HaLevi, revelation is everything. Revelation underpins everything. Not for Saadia."

### 2. No anthropomorphism

To the best of the Rabbi's knowledge, **Rav Saadia is the first to say that all the anthropomorphic images in the Torah must be taken non-literally**: the hand of Hashem, Hashem being happy or sad, going down or going up.

Why does the Torah talk that way? **Because the Torah speaks in the language humans can understand.** "You can't explain to a three-year-old or a five-year-old what we talk about in our shiurim, about God being the primal force. You have to talk about God sitting there on a chair in heaven, judging us, with a long beard." The problem is that most people stay with that picture all their lives, and that, says Rav Saadia, is absolutely wrong.

But he does **not go as far as the Rambam**:

| | Believing in an anthropomorphic God is... |
|---|---|
| **Rav Saadia** | **Wrong**, but it does not make you a heretic |
| **The Rambam** (Hilchot Teshuvah, as learned together in the series on the Principles) | **Heresy**; such a person has no portion in the World to Come |
| **The Ra'avad's gloss** on that Rambam | **וכמה גדולים וטובים ממנו הלכו בזו המחשבה**: many greater than him held this view |

The Ra'avad's comment shows that **this was a widely held belief at the time, even among Hachamim**. Today "you won't find an educated and intellectual Jew who will believe in an anthropomorphic God," but in those days it was not simple, and Rav Saadia goes to great lengths to reject it.

### 3. Creation from nothing

Rav Saadia respects **Aristotle**, "but he doesn't think he's the all." The Rambam had a much closer relationship with Aristotle. This is one of the key places where **Rav Saadia argues strongly with Aristotle** and insists that **the world was created from nothing**. "These are basic things to us, but he is the one who articulates them for the very first time in clear philosophical language."

### 4. Every Jew has mitzvot

Rav Saadia argues that there is **a continuum of Jewish observance**: **there is not a Jew in the world who does not have mitzvot**. Even a completely non-religious Jew is always doing mitzvot he may not know about. The class would see later in the book why this matters philosophically to him. "People like to say these kinds of things nowadays, but he was already saying this a thousand years ago."

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## Part 4: Getting the Text

- In English the Rabbi found only two translations online: one **abridged**, and one **full, from 1948, by Rosenblatt** (the Yale translation, *The Book of Beliefs and Opinions*). Interestingly, there were many translations in other languages, Spanish and German among them.
- **The shiurim will read the Hebrew text**, translating and discussing it, "because you always have to understand things in the original language. It's not the original language, but it's closer at least."
- No edition has Hebrew and English side by side, so he suggested getting both: the Hebrew to follow the class, the English to prepare beforehand or review afterwards. He would post a recommended Hebrew edition on the group, and offered a group order for those attending in person.
- Checking live, he found that **Sefaria has the full Hebrew text** (with partial English), and promised to post the link. "I personally find it difficult to learn from computers," but it works.

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## Summary

1. **Rav Saadia Gaon (892-942):** born in Egypt, trained in Tiberias as a linguist, author of the first Hebrew dictionary and teacher of **Dunash ben Labrat** (*Dror Yikra*).
2. **He saved the unity of the Jewish calendar** in 922, when Eretz Yisrael and Bavel kept Pesach on different days.
3. **He fought the Karaites**, whose literalism lies behind our *chamin* on Shabbat morning.
4. **Gaon of Sura**, deposed after refusing to sign the Exilarch's ruling, **he wrote Emunot VeDeot in the years out of office**, and later forgave and cared for the son who had humiliated him.
5. **The book** is the first structured work of Jewish philosophy, written in Arabic, for **the pious who do not understand** and **the unobservant who could have faith**, against **Christianity, Islam and the Karaites**.
6. **Key ideas:** revelation is a "catch-all," not the pinnacle (unlike the Kuzari); **no anthropomorphism** (but not heresy, unlike the Rambam); **creation from nothing** against Aristotle; **every Jew has mitzvot**.

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## Coming Up

**Next week** (exceptionally at 6:15 to 7:15): a few words on **the title**, then into the text itself, beginning with Rav Saadia's **introduction**.

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